an 'on-track arrangement with the IMF' in order to access anything over 30% of the credit disbursement. Both the NDB and CRA require swap arrangements denominated in US dollars that completely contradict the stated intention of weakening dollar hegemony. Buried within the millenarian phraseology are some more frank admissions of this conservative approach: the BRICS declaration styles its new institutes as a 'complement to existing arrangements'.

The states of today's putative 'emerging powers' are fundamentally different from their radical predecessors whose language they have appropriated, operating in a fundamentally different international context. Some insist that their rise signifies the return of the state in a developmental capacity after its retreat from the economy during neoliberalism. It's hard to see this in the case of South Africa or Russia. India has had some experimentation with heterodox economics but even this limited interventionism looks set to end – aside from a corrupted crony-capitalist incarnation as in the Gujarat model – with the coming to power of Modi, a market fundamentalist. China certainly represents a different case. Its dramatic economic boom would have been unthinkable without the strong guiding hand of the Communist Party and significant state-owned sector. But extreme exploitation and ecological devastation are the prices paid for this version of export-led growth. China and Russia seem to have finally disproven the old liberal axiom that freer markets and democracy are congenitally entwined. In India, Modi's election stands to deepen the systemic oppression and social stratification that facile celebrations of the 'largest democracy in the world' have always found easy to ignore.

In Brazil, Lula's Workers Party combined neoliberal macroeconomic fundamentals with strong industrial policy underpinned by the state bank BNDES, with some downward redistribution through family-support grants and minimum wage increases and subsidies for soya and other commodity exporters. Defying the trend within BRICS, the Gini coefficient has come down in Brazil, although it remains one of the most unequal nations in the world. Despite these progressive linings, Brazil is party to one shared feature of all the BRICS – strong and growing authoritarianism. Its brutal, militarised police force, inherited from the dictatorship, competes with South Africa's for the annual civilian body count.

Whatever their differences in economic policy, the nature of their political system or the ideology of their ruling parties, the foreign policy of BRICS nations is determined by the same set of laws. They are all capitalist societies, whose states are driven to accumulate their own geopolitical power and advance the interests of the corporations and elites on which they depend. With varying degrees of success they are competing in capitalist globalisation and its existing institutions.